

To decide to choose your own values is to decide to philosophize. The attempt to examine one's values, to shape and rethink them in the light of one's own experience and reason, is a philosophical task. This philosophical task, which is the subject of this chapter, we call ethics.

Ethics is the study of morality. In other words, ethics is a branch of philosophy that tries to determine which things are morally good and which actions are morally right. Ethics deals with morality, but it is not the same as morality. Morality is the subject matter that ethics studies. So, what, exactly, is morality? **Morality** consists of the standards that an individual or a group has about what is right and wrong or good and evil. For example, suppose that you come home tired one day and for several hours don't answer your telephone, but listen on your answering machine to people's voices when they call and leave messages. When you finally take a call, it's a friend who's upset she couldn't reach you earlier and asks whether you were home. You were home, of course, but didn't feel like answering the phone though you heard her messages when she left them. You could tell the person the unvarnished truth, but you know she will feel angry and hurt. So, you consider lying and saying you weren't home. However, you believe it's wrong to lie. So, you tell her the truth. Here, your belief that lying is wrong is a moral standard that you follow and try to live up to.

Generally speaking, moral standards deal with matters to which we attach great importance. For example, most people in U.S. society believe in moral standards against lying, theft, rape, enslavement, murder, child abuse, assault, slander, fraud, and lawbreaking. All of these plainly deal with matters that people feel are quite serious. A person's moral standards typically come from many different sources and influences, including parents, church, school, television, friends, magazines, music, and associations.

So, what, exactly, is ethics? Ethics begins when a person reflects on her moral standards or the moral standards of her society and asks whether these standards are reasonable or unreasonable, whether they are supported by good reasons or poor ones. A person starts to do ethics when she takes the moral standards that she has absorbed from her family, her church, her society—and asks questions: Do these standards really make sense? What are the reasons for or against these standards? Why should I continue to believe in them? What can be said in their favor, and what can be said against them? Are they reasonable or stupid? Suppose, for example, that after you hang up the phone, you ask yourself whether telling your friend the truth about why you didn't answer her earlier calls was stupid. Telling the truth just hurt her feelings and made her upset with you. Is it sometimes permissible to lie? Are some things—such as people's feelings—more important than telling the truth? Why is honesty so important, anyway? What makes lying wrong? Is lying wrong because lying injures people? Then, is lying right when telling the truth will hurt people more? What makes something right and wrong, and why are these so important?

When a person asks these kinds of questions about her moral standards or about the moral standards of her society, she has started to do ethics. Therefore, ethics is the study of moral standards. It aims at developing standards that we feel are reasonable to hold, standards that we have thought about and have decided are justified.

We begin our study of ethics by looking at an important challenge to ethics. This is the theory philosophers call ethical relativism, which holds that moral right and wrong depend on the culture a person belongs to. As you will see, this theory implies that we cannot say that one culture's moral beliefs are any better or worse than another's. But as you will also see, the theory of ethical relativism carries with it a number of serious problems.

*He cannot long be good
that knows not why he is
good.*

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RICHARD CAREW

QUICK REVIEW

Ethics is the study of morality; it involves reflecting on one's moral standards or the moral standards of a group or a society, and asking whether they are reasonable.

QUESTIONS

1. Consider the following list of overarching values (developed by psychologist Milton Rokeach), and rank them in order of their importance to you: freedom, security, equality, beauty, peace, love, pleasure, salvation, excitement, comfort, self-respect, friendship, knowledge, contentment, inner harmony, wisdom, sense of accomplishment. Now consider the following personal qualities, and rank them in order of their importance to you: being logical, forgiving, clean, loving, obedient, honest, polite, responsible, ambitious, self-disciplined, open-minded, cheerful, competent. Look over both lists and ask yourself whether there are any conflicts between the personal qualities you value and the overarching values you have. What conclusions can you draw about yourself?
2. Are other values or personal qualities important to you not mentioned in the preceding lists?
3. Do you feel that you have chosen your own moral values, or have your moral values been imposed on you by your parents, school, peers, and society? To the extent that your moral values are imposed on you, can you do anything about changing them? What?
4. Explain the difference between ethics and morality.

PHILOSOPHY AT THE MOVIES

Watch *The Woodsman* (2004), which recounts the story of Walter, a convicted sex offender just released from prison, who, trying to start a new life with Vickie who's aware of his history, finds he can escape neither himself nor his past. What values do you think should guide Vickie as she tries to decide how to relate to Walter? Should Walter be allowed to start a new life as he wants to do? Why or why not?



7.2 Is Ethics Relative?

Ethics is not the only way to study morality. Sociology, anthropology, psychology, and other social sciences also study morality. But the social sciences study morality through a descriptive or factual investigation of moral behavior and beliefs. These sciences are concerned with how people in fact behave or what people in fact believe. Ethics asks how people should behave or what people should believe. For example, anthropologists tell us that the Inuit (Eskimos) used to abandon their elderly on the ice and allow them to die of starvation and exposure. They also inform us that some African tribes kill infant twins and require that a man marry his brother's widow. But anthropology, as such, does not try to determine whether it was right for the Inuit to abandon their elderly in this way. Neither does it try to decide whether it is right for African tribes to kill infant twins. Ethics, on the other hand, tries to answer the question of whether it is *right* for the Inuit, in their circumstances, to abandon their elderly. It tries to decide whether killing infant twins is *right* for African tribes, in their circumstances. Ethics asks how people should live, whereas the social sciences ask how people actually do live.

Although ethics and the social sciences study morality in very different ways, both have addressed one important issue. Many social scientists have been impressed by how different the moralities of different societies are. For example, many societies think that slavery is unjust, whereas others have felt slavery is permissible; some societies believe that infanticide is wrong, but other societies practice it

*There is nothing either
good or bad, But thinking
makes it so.*

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WILLIAM
SHAKESPEARE

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Cultural relativism affirms that societies differ in their moral standards.

frequently. This is also the case with differences regarding the morality of many activities, including abortion, polygamy, patricide, slavery, suicide, nepotism, sexual and ethnic discrimination, genocide, homosexuality, euthanasia, pornography, pedophilia, and the torture of animals. This diversity of moral standards has led many social scientists to embrace a view called *cultural relativism*. Cultural relativism holds that different cultures have different moralities and that what one culture believes is wrong, another culture may believe is right. In other words, cultural relativism is the view that what people actually believe about morality depends on the culture in which they live. Cultural relativism is undoubtedly valid. Still, many social scientists have gone a step further and embraced *ethical relativism*, which is really a philosophical view and one that might be false.

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Ethical absolutism is the view that there is one and only one correct set of moral standards that everyone should follow everywhere and always.

To understand ethical relativism, one must first be familiar with ethical absolutism. **Ethical absolutism** states that one and only one correct morality exists. Absolutists maintain that this one morality applies to everyone, everywhere, and always, although not everyone follows it or believes in it. What is a moral duty for me must also be a duty for you. What is a moral duty for an American must also be a moral duty for an Asian, African, European, or aborigine. If lying is wrong, it is wrong for everyone, always, everywhere. That a society may see nothing wrong with pedophilia, lying, or cannibalism in no way affects the rightness or wrongness of such actions. Ethical absolutists do not necessarily claim that their own morality is the true and valid one. Yet they do insist that there is one true morality that is the same for all people in all ages and places.

Ethical relativism denies the existence of a single, universally applicable moral standard. As the name implies, ethical relativists insist that the correct morality is relative to one's society: Each society has its own morality, and an action is morally right for a person if the morality of one's society approves of the action. In short, ethical relativism holds that because there is no morality that all societies follow, each person should follow the morality of his or her own particular society.

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Ethical relativism argues that because societies differ in the moral standards they accept, it follows that there is no single correct set of moral standards everyone should adopt; instead, people should follow the standards that their own society accepts.

It is important to see that ethical relativism is not cultural relativism. As mentioned earlier, cultural relativism is the view that different societies believe in different moralities. Cultural relativism is a sociological fact: Research proves the existence of many obviously different moralities. But ethical relativists are not merely saying that what people in one part of the world *think* is right, people in a different part of the world *think* is wrong. Rather, ethical relativists assert that the same action that *is right* in one society actually *is wrong* in another. For example, anthropologists have shown that people in the jungles of New Guinea think that putting anyone over eighty years old to death is not wrong, whereas people in the United States clearly think that this is wrong. But the ethical relativist goes further and says that putting octogenarians to death *is* really right when one is a member of New Guinea society and it *is* really wrong when one is a member of U.S. society. In brief, ethical relativists believe that whatever the members of a society *think* is right for them to do is *in fact* what is right for them to do.

Many people have adopted the view that something is morally right if and only if their society thinks it is morally right. Yet this doctrine is very difficult to defend when we critically examine it. For example, how are we supposed to decide what “the ethical beliefs of a society” are? For example, does “U.S. society” think that abortion is right or that it is wrong? Does our society think that euthanasia is right or that it is wrong? Because our society is so deeply divided on these issues, saying what our society believes on these matters is impossible.

There is a deeper problem here. Ethical relativism says that something is morally right for a person if the person's society thinks that it is morally right. Suppose that it is a fact that all or almost all Americans believe that abortion is right. Surely

Modern morality consists in accepting the standard of one's age.

.....
OSCAR WILDE

it doesn't follow that I myself must hold that abortion is right. Yet ethical relativism says that if my society believes that something is morally right, then it must be morally right for me also. Or suppose that everyone in my society except me believes that slavery is right. Surely it doesn't follow that I must be wrong if I think slavery is unjust. Indeed, if society's beliefs determine what the correct morality is for me, then I can never criticize my own society.

Let's look more closely at this problem. Consider that if ethical relativism were correct, then the only moral standards we could use to make moral judgments in a certain society would be the moral standards of that society. But then it wouldn't make sense to say that these moral norms are themselves morally wrong. For example, it wouldn't make sense for an American in pre-Civil War southern society to say that the prevailing moral standard that permitted slavery is itself morally wrong. For what moral norms could the southerner use other than those of his own society, which say that slavery is moral? In the same way, ethical relativism implies that I cannot criticize the moral norms of my society, so I must conform to them. For the ethical relativist, morality is conformity.

But the basic problem with ethical relativism is the argument that is supposed to prove it. The ethical relativist argues that the many cultural disagreements about moral matters show that no morality is valid for all societies. But isn't this a strange argument? When cultures disagree about some issue, does it follow that there is no objective absolute truth about that issue? When people disagree about an issue, does it follow that all beliefs about that issue are equally acceptable? Philosopher James Rachels puts the matter quite succinctly:

The fact that different societies have different moral codes proves nothing. There is also disagreement from society to society about scientific matters: in some cultures people believe that the earth is flat, and that evil spirits cause disease. We do not on that account conclude that there is no truth in geography or in medicine. Instead, we conclude that in some cultures people are better informed than in others. Similarly, disagreement in ethics might signal nothing more than that some people are less enlightened than others. At the very least, the fact of disagreement does not, by itself, entail that truth does not exist. Why should we assume that, if ethical truth exists, everyone must know it?⁴

There are other problems with ethical relativism. Is it really true that there are no moral standards that all societies recognize? Think about it. If a society is going to survive, don't its members have to accept some moral standards about how they should behave toward one another? Won't a society collapse if its members don't recognize the moral standard to refrain from arbitrarily murdering their neighbors? Won't the language of a society collapse if its members don't recognize the moral standard of telling the truth? Won't a society's ability to make contracts and agreements collapse if its members don't recognize the obligation to keep one's promises? Although societies may differ in many of their moral beliefs, aren't there certain basic moral standards that all societies have to accept just to survive?

Moreover, even when two societies seem to have very different moral standards, at a deeper, more fundamental level, the two societies may share the same moral values. For example, take infanticide, the practice of killing newborn infants. Some societies condemn this practice, whereas others, such as certain Inuit societies, have allowed it. What accounts for these differences? Societies that condemn infanticide do so because they value human life. Does this show that societies that practice

*Right and wrong exist
in the nature of things.
Things are not right be-
cause they are commanded,
nor wrong because they are
prohibited.*

.....
R. G. INGERSOLL

*A good man does nothing
for the sake of appearance,
but for the sake of doing
right.*

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EPICTETUS

4 James Rachels, "Can Ethics Provide Answers?" *Hastings Center Report* 10, no. 3 (June 1980): 34.

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Problems with ethical relativism include these:

- (1) When people in a society disagree on the standards they accept, whose should be followed?
- (2) Ethical relativism implies that one has to accept society's views and not question them.
- (3) From the fact that societies differ in the moral standards they accept, it does not follow that there is not one correct group of moral standards.
- (4) There are some moral values that all societies must accept if they are to survive.

Morals are a personal affair; in the war of righteousness every man fights for his own hand.

ROBERT LOUIS
STEVENSON

infanticide do not value human life? Hardly. Anthropologists have noted that societies that permit infanticide exist in harsh physical environments and that they allow infanticide during times of great want. They allow infanticide to ensure that their society can survive and human life can continue.⁵ So, societies that permit infanticide do so because they, too, value human life. Nevertheless, to secure the survival of human life in their harsh environments, such societies must resort to the extreme measure of allowing infanticide. Societies, then, may share the same fundamental moral values. But their different circumstances or their different beliefs about the world may lead them to pursue these moral values through moral standards that, on the surface, look very different. The relativist is wrong, then, in claiming that the different moral standards found in different cultures show that there are no universal values recognized in all cultures.

Although the many objections to ethical relativism imply that it is mistaken, we should not reject the theory altogether. A fundamental point the theory is trying to make is that we should be tolerant of the moral beliefs of others. In particular, we should not assume that our own moral beliefs are the correct ones or even the best ones. The moral beliefs embedded in a culture different from our own have been fashioned over many centuries in response to the particular circumstances of that culture. For example, societies that face extreme hardships must adapt to those hardships with moralities that may look very different from ours. Their moralities may be trying to achieve the same basic human values for which we strive. In fact, some societies may have hit upon moral outlooks that are much better responses to the world than our own are. We should, then, be tolerant and respectful of those different moral outlooks.

Yet having respect and tolerance does not mean that we cannot criticize and evaluate the moral beliefs of other cultures and those of our own culture. For example, we can ask whether the moral beliefs of our own society are reasonable, whether they are consistent, whether they look toward the true well-being of our society, whether they conform to the facts of human nature, whether they respect the dignity of persons, and whether they help produce admirable moral characters. We can ask these same questions of the moral beliefs of other cultures. Asking questions like these may lead us to conclude that our own moral beliefs are defective and that the moral beliefs of other societies are closer to adequate than ours are. Ethical relativism, which says that your society must determine your moral beliefs, would not allow you to reach this conclusion.

We can't explore ethical relativism any further. Whether we agree with the absolutist or the relativist stance, each of us must still decide what we ought to do individually and collectively. Presumably, this action requires some reasonable moral standard on which to base decisions. So, whether I am an absolutist or a relativist, the question remains: What is it reasonable to hold about how I ought to behave and what my society ought to do?

QUESTIONS

1. Explain the difference between cultural relativism and ethical relativism. Do you think that the fact that people disagree about moral right and wrong shows that ethical relativism is true? Explain.
2. During World War II, the Nazis in Germany believed that exterminating Jews and homosexuals was morally justifiable. Would an ethical relativist say that it was morally right to invade Nazi Germany to prevent the Germans from exterminating Jews and homosexuals? Explain.

5 Glenn Hausfater and Sarah B. Hrdy, *Infanticide* (Hawthorne, NY: Aldine de Gruyter), 1984.

3. Listen to some of your friends discussing or arguing about some moral issue—that is, some issue that involves right and wrong or good and evil. On the basis of how they argue about the issue, would you say that they are relativists or absolutists? Next, ask them directly whether they are relativists or absolutists. Do any of your friends seem to be absolutists when they argue about a moral issue, yet say that they are relativists? Explain what you think is going on in such cases.
4. Explain this statement: “For the ethical relativist, morality is conformity.”
5. Is the relativist or the absolutist more tolerant of people in his own society who have moral views that differ from those of the majority? Explain your answer.

PHILOSOPHY AT THE MOVIES

Watch *Nowhere in Africa* (*Nirgendwo in Afrika*) (2001) in which Walter, a Jew living in Germany during the Nazi era, travels to Africa as World War II is about to break out. When he has his family join him there, he discovers that, while his daughter Regina quickly adjusts to their new home, his wife, Jettel, dislikes Africa and their life there. List the many ethical issues this movie raises. Was it wrong for Jettel to agree to the British soldier’s request? Was it wrong for Walter to insist the family return to Germany? Does this film depict cultural relativism? ethical relativism? Does the film imply or reject the idea that people of different cultures ultimately have the same values?

Movie with a related theme: *Enemy Mine* (1985).



7.3 Do Consequences Make an Action Right?

Consider this true story:

Matthew Donnelly was a physicist who had worked with X-rays for thirty years. Perhaps as a result of too much exposure, he contracted cancer and lost part of his jaw, his upper lip, his nose, and his left hand, as well as two fingers from his right hand. He was also left blind. Mr. Donnelly’s physicians told him that he had about a year left to live, but he decided that he did not want to go on living in such a state. He was in constant pain—one writer said that “at its worst, he could be seen lying in bed with teeth clenched and beads of perspiration standing out on his forehead.” Knowing that he was going to die eventually anyway, and wanting to escape his misery, Mr. Donnelly begged his three brothers to kill him. Two refused, but one did not. The youngest brother, 36-year-old Harold Donnelly, carried a .30-caliber pistol into the hospital and shot Matthew to death.⁶

When questioned, Harold Donnelly said that he did not feel that killing his brother was immoral. It was much better for his brother to die than to suffer the terrible consequences of continuing to live. The consequences justified the killing.

Traditionally, many ethicists have contended that we should decide moral right and wrong by looking at the consequences of our actions. If the consequences are good, the act is right. If the consequences are bad, the act is wrong. Thus, a **consequentialist theory** measures the morality of an action by its nonmoral consequences. Consequentialists consider the ratio of good to evil that an action produces. The right action is the one that produces or will probably produce as great a ratio of good to evil as any other action. The wrong action is the one that does not.

For example, suppose that while driving down an almost deserted street one night, you momentarily take your eyes off the road and strike a parked car. You stop

⁶ James Rachels, *The Elements of Moral Philosophy* (New York: Random House, 1986), 82.